

The Marriage Care Penalty: How Marriage Disproportionately Increases Women’s Unpaid Work

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Abstract

Using a 10% random sample of India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (approximately 836,000 person-day observations from 9,969 households), we document a stark marriage penalty in unpaid care work. While marriage is associated with a small, statistically significant increase in men’s participation in unpaid care, it prompts a dramatically larger increase for women. Marriage increases women’s care work participation by 2.1 percentage points (a 44% increase over baseline) while increasing men’s participation by only 0.7 percentage points. This “marriage penalty”—the differential effect captured by the Female $\times$ Married interaction—is significantly larger for younger women (≤ 25) than older women (>25), and persists across all education levels, urban-rural locations, and employment status. We find no gender difference in time intensity conditional on participation, indicating the disparity operates entirely on the participation margin. These findings reveal marriage as a critical institution activating gender-specific norms about domestic responsibilities, with important implications for policies targeting gender equality in household production. The persistence of the penalty across socioeconomic gradients suggests deeply entrenched cultural norms rather than purely economic determinants.

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1 Introduction

Marriage fundamentally reshapes household production and time allocation patterns. Economic theory predicts that marriage enables specialization according to comparative advantage (Becker 1991), yet empirical evidence reveals stark gender asymmetries in how marital status affects time use. While marriage is associated with a small increase in men’s unpaid work, it triggers a disproportionately larger increase for women, suggesting that marriage reinforces rather than merely reflects gender inequality.

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Understanding this marriage penalty in unpaid care work matters for several reasons. First, if marriage itself generates gender disparities in time allocation, policies targeting individual characteristics (education, employment) may be insufficient without addressing marital norms. Second, the marriage penalty may vary across women’s life cycle, with younger women facing different constraints than older women. Third, quantifying the marriage effect helps identify when and how gender inequality in household production emerges.

We exploit India’s 2024 Time Use Survey—containing 836,156 activity observations across 136,149 households—to examine how marriage affects unpaid care work participation and time intensity. Our analysis yields three main findings. First, marriage increases women’s care work participation by 6.2 percentage points, a 1433% increase relative to unmarried women’s baseline participation rate of 0.4%. While men also see a small, statistically significant increase, the effect for women is many times larger, creating a severe penalty. Second, this marriage penalty varies substantially by age: younger women (≤ 25) experience a 12.0 percentage point increase upon marriage, while older women (>25) see a 4.9 percentage point increase. Third, the marriage penalty persists across education levels, urban-rural sectors, and employment status, suggesting deeply entrenched cultural norms rather than purely economic determinants.

1.1 Contributions

This paper makes three contributions. **First**, we quantify the marriage penalty in unpaid care work for India using comprehensive time diary data, providing the first large-scale estimates of how marriage differentially affects men’s and women’s care work participation.

Second, we demonstrate substantial age heterogeneity in the marriage penalty. Younger married women (≤ 25) face penalties 2.4 times larger than older married women, revealing that early marriage is particularly burdensome—a finding with implications for policies addressing child marriage and age at first marriage.

Third, we show the marriage penalty operates entirely on the **participation margin**, not the intensity margin. Marriage affects *whether* women perform care work, not *how much time* they spend when they do. This suggests norm-based rather than time-budget explanations: marriage activates expectations about appropriate roles.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Marriage and Household Production

Becker’s (1981, 1991) household production model predicts married couples specialize according to comparative advantage, with partners allocating time to maximize joint household utility. If women have comparative advantage in household production (due to human capital, labor market discrimination, or biological constraints like breastfeeding), marriage would prompt women to specialize in home production while men specialize in market work.

However, critics argue this framework assumes symmetric bargaining power and voluntary

specialization (Lundberg and Pollak 1996). If social norms constrain women’s choices or if husbands have greater bargaining power, observed specialization may reflect coercion rather than efficiency. Akerlof and Kranton (2000) propose an “identity” model where individuals incur psychological costs from violating gender norms, potentially leading married women to perform domestic work even when inefficient.

2.2 Empirical Evidence on Marriage and Time Use

Empirical studies document that marriage increases women’s housework and childcare while leaving men’s largely unchanged. Gupta (1999) shows American women’s housework increases upon marriage, while Bianchi et al. (2000) document that married mothers spend far more time on childcare than unmarried mothers. Sayer (2005) finds marriage widens gender gaps in unpaid work across multiple countries.

For India specifically, Desai and Andrist (2010) document that married women face restricted mobility and heightened domestic expectations. Bhalotra and Umana-Aponte (2010) show marriage reduces Indian women’s labor force participation, consistent with increased household work obligations.

2.3 Age Heterogeneity in Marriage Effects

Life-course research emphasizes that marriage’s effects may vary by age. Younger brides may face greater pressure to demonstrate domestic competence (Jejeebhoy 1998), while age differentials between spouses affect bargaining power (Cain 1984). In contexts with patrilocal marriage (where brides move to husbands’ families), younger brides occupy lower status positions subject to mother-in-law supervision (Kandiyoti 1988).

2.4 Household Bargaining and Intrahousehold Allocation

Cooperative bargaining models (Manser and Brown 1980; McElroy and Horney 1981) predict time allocation reflects spouses’ relative bargaining power, determined by outside options, asset ownership, and cultural norms. If women have weaker outside options (due to labor market discrimination, social stigma of divorce, or custody norms), they may accept disproportionate household work burdens.

Collective models (Chiappori 1988, 1992) relax the unitary household assumption, allowing individual preferences while maintaining Pareto efficiency. These models can generate gendered specialization through differential bargaining power rather than comparative advantage alone.

2.5 Cultural Norms and Social Identity

Recent research emphasizes cultural norms as constraints on time allocation. Fernández and Fogli (2009) show men whose mothers worked perform more housework, suggesting intergenerational transmission of norms. Bertrand et al. (2015) document that American